speaking with new foreign minister Vajpayee, emphasized that there would not be a major change—the trends that had begun under Gandhi would continue—but there would be a difference in nuance.[100]

This shift nonetheless created space for an improved US relationship. Desai, as an Indian editor observed, was not distrustful of the US or the West as Gandhi had been.[101] Moreover, the Carter administration's approach in some ways was more attuned with Indian preferences: its stress on regional influentials; Carter's call for getting over the "inordinate fear of communism"; the administration's appreciation of the "limits of influence"; and its recognition of the need to consider countries "in their own right" and not as a subset of the Cold War.[102] Finally, India needed the US (and the West more broadly) to diversify its partnerships as a source for trade, investment, and technology, as well as for the recognition the US could give India in the region.[103]

Carter, on his part, was ready to do something, telling Brzezinski that he wanted to "start some personal and strong effort toward Desai—perhaps involving the Indian Ocean."[104] Brzezinski told Secretary of State Cyrus Vance that regular discussions with Delhi on Indian Ocean arms control could be a platform to improve relations and put the Soviet Union—which had a base in Berbera on the Gulf of Aden—on the back foot.[105]

The White House realized, however, that an India-Soviet split was neither a feasible nor a desirable objective. Brzezinski knew that as long as India's relations with China remained strained, the Soviet Union would remain a "strategic asset" for India. It was also critical to Delhi for spare parts and technology supply.[106] Thornton, on his part, warned that pushing Moscow out meant that Washington might have to pick up the slack on China, and "We certainly don't want … to become a military guarantor of India against China." He emphasized that "Zero-sum" and "soak the Soviets" initiatives were easy, but the Carter administration should not fall for the "great power competition trap in the Third World" as Kissinger had.[107] Nonetheless, to get a conversation with India going, the US started updating Indian officials on their Indian Ocean talks with Moscow and soliciting their views.[108]

Five months into the administration, Brzezinski took stock and told Carter that decisions were needed in his four key foreign policy areas: relations with Moscow, Africa, and the Middle East and North-South